

IN CONTEXT

Des Knaben Wunderhorn

First published in the early 19th century, Des Knaben Wunderhorn (The Boy's Magic Horn) was a collection of traditional German folk verse and songs edited by Romantic poets Achim von Arnim and Clemens Brentano. Their subjects ranged from talking fish and donkeys to soldiers and angels. Between 1887 and 1901, Mahler wrote 24 songs based on Des Knaben Wunderhorn, assembling 12 into a song cycle of that name. He also used the songs in his Second, Third, and Fourth Symphonies. Mahler admired the folk verses as being “more nature and life than art.”



“IN THE FOREST”, FROM DES KNABEN WUNDERHORN, ILLUSTRATION,
1848

Born in 1860, Gustav Mahler grew up in the rural town of Iglau (now Jihlava) on the border between Moravia and Bohemia. Many of his early experiences were harsh. His father, a German-speaking Jewish trader who owned a liquor store, was a wife-